Sporting Fella

Q+A

IN NETFLIX'S *VIJAY 69*, ANUPAM KHER PLAYS A 69-YEAR-OLD WHO DECIDES TO COMPETE IN A TRIATHLON. THE ACTOR TALKS ABOUT WHY HE CONTINUES TO CHALLENGE HIMSELF



Photograph by MILIND SHELTE

Q. Did the role challenge you?
It absolutely did. I didn't know how to swim and, in the film, Vijay does a triathlon, of which swimming is an integral part. I told Akshay that I'd like to learn, because I didn't want them to use a double. I was afraid, but I managed to conquer that fear. You need to constantly reinvent yourself and learn new things. The fear of failing is what makes you mediocre.

Q. This is your 40th year in the movies. What advice would you give your 28-something self working on his first film?
I would tell him to stay as fearless as you are. It was brave to have accepted playing a 65-year-old in my first film and that trait has stayed with me. If you don't take risks, it's really hard to make a mark. *Vijay 69* was a very tough film for me physically. I am lucky to be the lead of a sports film at my age.

Q. Does playing your own age on screen make a difference in any way?
This is the first time I've done that. I was 28 when I played a 65-year-old in *Saaransh*. In this film, my character at heart is 28. It feels like a full-circle moment. I was 68 when Akshay Roy [writer, director] came to meet me with this script. My character's age was always 69, much like shops that price items at 99.

Q. Having done almost 600 films, do you still have a wish list for a certain kind of role or story?
I am truly very lucky to be getting the kind of work I am getting. I had *The Signature* release a few weeks ago that got a lot of appreciation...the film needed deep introspection. While I am a product of masala films, I enjoy making my life difficult by signing films that challenge me. I've done films like *The Kashmir Files*, *Uunchai*, *Khosla Ka Ghosla!* and *A Wednesday*.

–with Karishma Upadhyay